

Karakorum Highlights

Country(ies): Pakistan

Tour type: Small Group

Transport: 4x4 jeep

Group size: Min: 2 | Max: 16

Days: 15 days

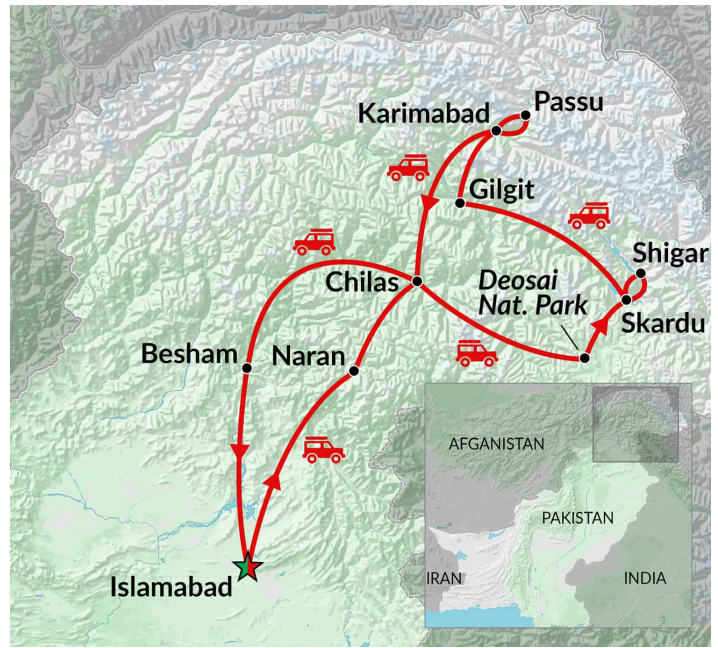
Start Location: Islamabad, Pakistan

End Location: Islamabad, Pakistan

Meals: Breakfasts - 14, Lunches - 13, Dinners - 13

Highlights:

Karakorum Highway; Hikes to Fairy Meadows, Beyal Camp, Nanga Parbat BC (optional), Herrlikoffer BC & Passu Glacier; Deosai Plains; Shigar Valley; Khorpocho, Baltit & Altit Forts; Borith Lake; Hussaini hanging bridge; Sunset at Duikar viewpoint.



Itinerary

Day 1: Arrive in Islamabad, afternoon city tour

This morning we will welcome you to Pakistan at Islamabad airport and transfer you to your hotel. At 2pm your guide will meet you at the hotel and take you on an afternoon tour of Pakistan's modern capital. Our visits will include the huge Faisal Mosque, which is the 6th largest in the world and the biggest in South Asia. We'll also visit the Pakistan Monument which was constructed to symbolise the unity of the Pakistan people, and the impressive Heritage Museum which presents the history and living traditions of the people of Pakistan both from the main stream and the remotest regions of the country.

Extra nights are available in the hotel before the tour starts if morning arrival flights are not available or convenient.

OVERNIGHT: Islamabad hotel

MEALS: None

EXTRAS: Extra night in Islamabad - pre-tour (EXPAIS) Single Room Supplement (PASGHK) Guide & Transport for extra day - Islamabad (EXPAGI)

Day 2: Islamabad to Naran via the Jaulian Monastery & Sirkup Old City. Visit Naran Bazaar

We leave modern Islamabad this morning and start our drive up into the hills to the north. Our journey takes us along the photogenic, 160km-long Khagan valley, which is embraced by the forested peaks of the lesser Himalayan range. Along the way we visit the Jaulian Monastery and Sirkup Old City. Explore the ruins of Jaulian, a Buddhist monastery, and imagine the serene lives of monks who once resided there. Finally, walk among the relics of Sirkup, a bustling city from the Kushan era, picturing its grand streets and marketplaces

Naran is one of Pakistan's most popular summer holiday spots and is famous for its colourful panorama. Naran itself is situated on the banks of the Kunhar river, and we have some time to look around before spending the night here. Immerse yourself in the lively atmosphere of Naran Bazaar. Browse vibrant stalls overflowing with handcrafted souvenirs, local textiles, and delicious street food. You can also engage with friendly vendors and discover unique treasures that capture the essence of this mountain town.

OVERNIGHT: Hotel in Naran

MEALS: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 3: Cross the Babussar Pass. Hike to Fairy Meadows

Prepare for some serious hairpin bends today as the road climbs up to the Babussar Pass (4175m) and then descends again towards Chilas, situated on the banks of the mighty Indus River. En-route we'll stop for a break at Lulusar Lake. We continue up the Karakorum Highway to Raikot Bridge (2300m) and then follow a narrow jeep track to Tato village. The track clings to the side of the mountain with steep drops below and we'll be thankful for our experienced driver! We leave the vehicles at Jhel Village there and take a 2-3 hour/5km trek to Fairy Meadows (3300m). This is a strenuous uphill walk, which includes a gradual climb for most of the route, with one

steep final section of around 30 minutes (total elevation gain around 650m). Horses can be hired locally for around 3000Rs per person (approx. GBP 13 / USD 18) if you don't want to walk up.

This a legendary place, well named by German climbers, and has an unsurpassed view of Nanga Parbat (8125m).

OVERNIGHT: Fairy Meadows Huts

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 4: Free time or treks in the mountains around Fairy Meadows

Fairy Meadows (3300m) is one of the most picturesque places in the world, and the start of some fantastic mountain trekking routes. There are two options today. The easier choice is a 2-3 hour trek through dense prime forest, and then through birch trees and along shallow streams up to Beyal Camp (3500m). This is a summer settlement for the local shepherds and has stunning views of Nanga Parbat. An easy walk takes you back down to Fairy Meadows to enjoy a camp fire after dinner.

The other, tougher option is continue on from Beyal Camp for another 3 to 4 hours to reach Nanga Parbat Base Camp (3967m, 500m ascent). Suitable for fit, and experienced trekkers, this is an 8 to 9 hour round trip, but well worth it if you're up for it,

For those preferring a more relaxed pace, Fairy Meadows is a good location for a relaxed stroll, or wildlife spotting; keep your eyes peeled for marmots, Himalayan ibex, and colorful birds. The remote location of Fairy Meadows makes it a perfect spot for star gazing at night.

OVERNIGHT: Fairy Meadows huts

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 5: Hike down to Tato, drive to Tarashing

We'll leave Fairy Meadows reluctantly this morning and after breakfast hike back down to Tato (approx. 1 1/2 to 2 hours), pick up our vehicles again, and then drive on to Tarashing, through the magnificent, pine forested Astore Valley which feels reminiscent of Austrian scenes (around 3 to 4 hours drive). The roads become smaller and narrower and eventually we reach the remote village of Tarashing, the last village at the head of the jeep road towards the Rupal face of Nanga Parbat. The village is watered by Tarashing Glacier which follows the route to the base camp. The fields around the village offer picturesque scenery and the flower blossom in summer is superb.

OVERNIGHT: Tarashing guest house

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 6: Hike to Nanga Parbat-Herrligkoffer Base Camp

We have another stunning mountain trek today. We'll start by driving from Tarashing (2911m) into the the Rupal Valley, following the Tarashing (or Chhungphar) glacier's lateral moraine before crossing it and continuing to Rupal Village. From there we hike through small settlements and past herds of yaks and cattle to the Herrligkoffer Base Camp (3550m) at the foot of Nanga Parbat. The camp site is named after a German mountaineer, Karl

Herrligkoffer, who led the first successful expedition to reach the peak of Nanga Parbat in 1953. The overall trek is around 8km, taking around 4 hours.

Back at Tarashing, there will be free time in the village to chat to friendly locals and see how life is lived in these remote areas where the glacial water supply is vital and ever decreasing.

OVERNIGHT: Tarashing guest house

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 7: To Skardu via Desosai National Park

Our route today takes us through the Deosai National Park. These plains are a contrast to the steep valleys we've traversed so far, and lie between the Indus River and the souther extension of the Himalayas. The altitude averages 3800m, and the undulating green, flower-filled meadows are surrounded by snow capped peaks. Fresh water lakes abound, helping to make this seldom disturbed area a haven for wildlife, including Brown Bear and Markhor. After driving across the plains, we continue to Skardu, the capital of the Baltistan region. Known as 'Little Tibet', this area has one of the highest clusters of mountains in the world, and has ancient ties with nearby Tibet.

We'll break the journey to Skardu at the beautiful Satpura Lake, another large lake at the foot of the plains, and visit the Manthal Buddha, a large granite rock into which a picture of Buddha has been engraved, probably sometime in the 8th century. This is one of the most important relics of Buddhism in the Skardu region.

OVERNIGHT: Skardu hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 8: Day trip to the Shigar Valley

We take a day trip from Skardu to the fertile Shigar Valley today. We'll cross the Indus River, and head up the Shigar River which is surrounded by wide flat sand banks, deposited when the water levels are high. The lush green valley is a great contrast, and is well known for its fruit orchards. Shigar is inhabited mostly by Balti people of Tibetan descent, and has many historical buildings of architectural significance associated with the Noorbakhshi Sufi community. We'll visit the Amborik Mosque, and have lunch at Shigar Fort.

After returning to Skardu we can take a late afternoon hike to Khorpocho Fort, built in the 8th century on a hill overlooking Skardu. The main fort was destroyed in 1840, though the impressive boundary walls remain.

OVERNIGHT: Skardu hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 9: Skardu to Gilgit via Katchura Lake

After breakfast we'll drive back to the main Karakorum Highway and the town of Gilgit. The road hugs the banks of the Indus river all the way, and we can see various stretches of white water rapids. We'll make a stop on the way at the Katchura Lakes, and look out for the local wild apricot trees.

Gilgit is an important town, and was part of the Kushan Empire in the 1st to 3rd centuries. Buddhism persisted after the Kushan demise, though few traces remain - one being the Kargah Buddha, a rock wall carved in the 7th century. Gilgit is surrounded by high peaks, the most impressive being Rakaposhi (7,788m). We'll arrive in time to

visit the old British cemetery and the lively and eclectic bazaar. If we're lucky we may be able to see a Polo match; Polo is extremely popular through the region and matches between neighbouring towns happen throughout the summer.

OVERNIGHT: Gilgit Hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 10: Hunza Valley, Borith Lake, Passu Glacier View

We drive north again today on the newly reconstructed Karakorum Highway. Passing under the shadow of Rakaposhi, our two hour journey leads us to the former kingdom of Hunza, called "the epitome of mountain grandeur" by Eric Shipton. It is a fairy tale land surrounded by beautiful rugged & snow capped mountains; including Ultar (7,388m), Lady Finger (6000m), Diran (7,266m) and Rakaposhi (7,788m).

In the Upper Hunza Valley, we'll take a walk for around two hours from Borith Lake (2600m), up to a stunning viewpoint alongside the huge Passu Glacier. The saline waters are supposed to be good for the skin, and many people take a dip here in the summer months. The site is also an important sanctuary for migrating wildfowl. From the glacier, a path leads back down to the Karakorum Highway. We'll return to our hotel and there feast on some of the best food of the trip with both Indian and Chinese influences creating mouth watering dishes.

OVERNIGHT: Passu Hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 11: Passu to Karimabad

A short drive and walk after breakfast this morning brings us to the world famous Hussaini Suspension Bridge. Considered the second longest man made hanging bridge in the world, this stretches for several hundred metres across the Hunza River, with widely spaced wooden boards and a few wire ropes being all that is between you and the rushing river below. Take care if you want to cross it!

We'll then follow the river downstream and visit Gulmit village, Pamiri Musical School, a local museum and discover the KORGAH weaving center, where traditional craftsmanship meets modern social impact. This center supports women artisans in rural Pakistan, empowering them through the creation of beautiful, hand-woven textiles. Witness skilled weavers at work, learn about their ancient techniques, and perhaps even take home a unique piece that carries with it a story of sustainability and female empowerment.

In Karimabad, the main town of the Hunza Valley, we'll visit the Baltit Fort which was the old palace of the Mirs of Hunza. About 700 years old, the Baltit Fort sits on the edge of a cliff with a ravine below and the Ultar glacier in the distance.

OVERNIGHT: Karimabad hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 12: Altit Fort & Village, Duikar viewpoint

We'll take a walk around Karimabad this morning, following the main water channels. We can also visit the bazaar in Karimabad and if we're lucky, watch a polo match in the town. We'll also visit Altit Fort and Altit village. Like Baltit Fort, Tibetan architectural traditions are much in evidence. The fort is around 900 years old and has a splendid defensive position overlooking the Hunza river valley, and it also served as the home of the Mir of Hunza before the set of power moved to nearby Baltit (now Karimabad).

We'll also visit the CIQAM Project today - The CIQAM project is a remarkable initiative focused on empowering marginalized communities in the Hunza Valley of Pakistan. The project combines traditional craftsmanship with capacity building and skills training. CIQAM supports local artisans, especially women, in preserving their heritage while creating sustainable economic opportunities. The project encompasses textiles, woodwork, and other traditional crafts, highlighting the rich cultural tapestry of the region.

Late in the afternoon we'll drive up to the small village of Duikar (approx. 3000m) to enjoy a panoramic view of the Hunza Valley at sunset.

OVERNIGHT: Karimabad hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 13: Karakorum Highway to Besham or Naran

We have a long drive back down the Karakorum Highway today, enjoying a different perspective to the mountain views we saw on the way up. Heading to Gilgit, we'll see the junction of the three highest mountain ranges in the world, the Himalay, Karakorum and the Hindu Kush. Along the way, we'll make a stop near Chilas at Shatial to see the Petroglyphs there. An important historical crossroads, many Buddhist missionaries, pilgrims, Sogdian merchants and traders passed through Shatial and left inscriptions and graffiti on the rocks. Over 700 petroglyphs and 1000 inscriptions in more than ten languages can be found at the Shatial bridge across the Indus River. Depending on the weather, road and local security conditions, we have the option of following the original Karakorum Highway and taking the Westerly route through the mighty Indus Valley to Besham where we spend the night. This road follows the Indus for most of the rest of the day and travels through steep gorges, beneath high rock walls with the river rushing below us. Alternatively we will return via Barbusar Pass route, travelling through the Kaghan Valley again to overnight in Naran.

OVERNIGHT: Besham or Naran hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 14: Return to Islamabad via Taxila

Our final descent out of the mountains today crosses low lying hills on twisting roads to reach the 'Grand Trunk Road', built originally by the British to link Peshawa in the West to Calcutta in the East.

We'll stop on the way at Taxila, once an important seat of Oriental culture. First mentioned as a satrapy of the Archemenian empire in the 6th century BC, Taxila was later invaded by Alexander the Great and passed through the hands of various different rulers before being controlled by Ashoka the Great who focussed the city into an important centre of learning. Taxila remained an important place for philosophy, art and learning through the creative Gandhara period and on until the 5th century C.E.

We will finish the day and our trip with a walking tour through the Raja Bazaar in Rawalpindi, which sits adjacent to Islamabad. This old bazaar bustles with life and a stop in the silver and gold bazaars will allow us to watch traditional craftsmen at work, as well as perhaps pick up a final souvenir of our time in Pakistan.

OVERNIGHT: Rawalpindi hotel

MEALS: Breakfast,Lunch,Dinner

EXTRAS:

Day 15: Departure from Islamabad

Your time is free today until we transfer you back to Islamabad airport for your flight home.

Extra nights and additional guiding and transport are available in Islamabad or Rawalpindi if you would like to extend your stay, perhaps to add on a visit to Lahore to see the Fort, Mosque and Gardens. Please contact us for details.

OVERNIGHT: NULL

MEALS: Breakfast

EXTRAS: Lahore Extension

Included:

- Accommodation in comfortable hotels, guesthouses and cabins
- Airport arrival and departure transfers
- Transport in rugged 4x4 vehicles
- Visa invitation letter
- Sightseeing tours in Islamabad & Rawalpindi
- Various guided mountain hikes throughout the route
- Pakistani clothes (Shalwaar Chemise)
- Meals - 3 meals per day
- Tea & Coffee morning & afternoon
- Local English speaking guide

Excluded:

- International flights
- Visas
- Travel insurance (compulsory)
- Drinks, snacks & tips
- Other personal expenses (eg. laundry)
- Optional excursions

Notes

Note: Chilas-Besham-Mahsehra route

Our preferred route on our return from Karimabad to Islamabad is to follow the section of the classic Karakorum Highway on the N35 road from Chilas to Besham and on to Mansehra. However, subject to the current weather, road, and local security conditions, we may return from Chilas to Islamabad on the N15 road via the Barbusar Pass and Naran.

Options

Our tours are designed to include all that you need to enjoy a really special time in the destination you're visiting. However, we do also offer some extra options to complement the tour and add some additional sightseeing or activities, or some extra time at either end of the tour.

All accommodation based options (e.g. Single supplements, extra nights, cruise upgrades) should be booked and paid for in advance so that we can make the appropriate arrangements. Other options may either be booked and paid for in advance or while you are on the tour, though we recommend booking in advance to ensure there are no issues with availability.

Many options are priced the same throughout the year, but some may incur single or high season supplements - full details are given on the tour reservation form or on request.

Single Room Supplement (PASGKH)

Min numbers: 1

This tour is based on twin-share accommodation, with single bookers paired up with another traveller of the same sex in the group. If the final group make-up means that no room share is available, you do not need to pay this supplement. However, if you would like to guarantee yourself a single room throughout the tour, then please add this option to your booking.

Note: Single supplement prices may vary seasonally.

Extra night in Islamabad - pre-tour (EXPAIS)

Min numbers: 1

This option adds an extra night in Islamabad to the start of your tour, staying in the same hotel as the main tour itself (subject to availability). Your airport arrival transfer is still included. Prices shown are per person and based on two people sharing.

Single room supplements apply.

Extra night in Islamabad - post-tour (EXPAIE)

Min numbers: 1

This option adds an extra night in Islamabad to the end of your tour, staying in the same hotel as the main tour itself (subject to availability). Your airport arrival transfer is still included. Prices shown are per person and based on two people sharing.

Single room supplements apply.

Guide & Transport for extra day - Islamabad (EXPAGI)

Min numbers: 1

If you will be adding extra nights to either end of your tour in Pakistan with us, then you may also wish to book a guide and vehicle for your extra day.

This option provides that guide and vehicle for you in Islamabad. The guide will also accompany you on your

arrival or departure airport transfer.
Solo traveller supplements apply.

Lahore Extension

Min numbers: 1

This option extends your time in Pakistan to visit the bustling city of Lahore, the second largest city in Pakistan. The extension includes 2 nights in Lahore, followed by a final night in Islamabad.

Day 1 - Drive from Islamabad to Lahore.

Leave Islamabad this morning, heading to Lahore. En-route we'll visit Rohtas Fort. In the afternoon, visit Lahore Fort & Badshahi Mosque. This evening we'll visit Gawalmandi Food Street - Dinner is not included but there are plenty of options to choose from. Overnight in 3-star hotel.

Day 2 - Exploring Lahore and visiting the Wagah Border.

Morning visit to Lahore Museum and Masjid Wazir Khan. Afternoon visit to Shalimar Garden. In the evening we'll visit the Wagah Border. Overnight in 3-star hotel. ?

Day 3 - Anarkali Bazar and Jahangir's Tomb. Return to Islamabad.

Morning visit to Anarkali Bazaar. Afternoon visit to Jahangir's Tomb and then drive back to Islamabad. Overnight in Islamabad hotel.

Day 4 - Transfer to Islamabad Airport.

You'll have free time in Islamabad today until you are transferred to the airport for departure.

Note: Pricing for this option is based on a minimum of 2 travellers, sharing a twin/double room. Single traveller rates apply.

1. Accommodation

This tour stays in a mix of different accommodation, based partly on what is available in some of the remote areas we are visiting. In Islamabad and Rawalpindi we stay in a comfortable tourist class hotel (locally rated 3 or 4 star), while hotels and guesthouses are more simple and with less facilities further up the KKH. Bathrooms are en-suite in nearly all locations.

Accommodation is based on a twin-share basis, with single room supplements available if you would like to guarantee yourself a single room throughout the tour.

2. Transport

The transport for this tour is based on using rugged local 4x4 jeeps. While the majority of the Karakorum Highway (KKH) has been improved and re-surfaced, we will also be travelling on some rough gravel tracks and roads where this type of vehicle is needed. We only use drivers experienced in driving on the KKH and on remote roads like these. Seatbelts are provided and should be worn.

3. Transfers

This tour includes your arrival and departure airport transfers and all other transfers throughout the itinerary. You will be provided with detailed information for where to meet our representative in the airport, as well as a local contact telephone number and our own 24-hour emergency phone number, when we send you your final tour voucher approximately two weeks before your departure.

If your flight arrives in the early hours of the morning, you may like to book an extra night in the hotel so a bed is available for you to get some rest and sleep before the tour starts. Subject to your arrival time, you may be able to rest in the reception area of the hotel until your room is available (we will aim to help you check in early, but this will be subject to the hotel's occupancy - standard check in times are 2-3pm).

4. Joining on Day 1

This trip starts with an afternoon tour of Islamabad on Day 1. We normally meet in the hotel at 1.30pm and leave at 2pm - this will be confirmed by our representative if we pick you up from the airport, or by a notice in the hotel reception if you are making your own arrangements to get to the hotel. If your flight arrives after around 11am on Day 1 you will miss this afternoon tour. Extra nights are available in the same tour hotel if morning arrival flights are not convenient for your dates or departure airport. During this first meeting with the guide, we will also collect a photocopy of your passport information page and your travel insurance policy details.

5. Activity Level

You do need to be relatively fit and mobile to enjoy this tour at its best. There are several days on this trip where hikes through the mountains are included. However, generally these are optional and can be skipped or shortened if you wish. We do not consider this to be a trekking tour - it is a sightseeing tour with some hikes and walks built into it. The only exception really is the walk up to Fairy Meadows on Day 3 where the accommodation can't be reached by vehicle. This is a strenuous uphill walk of around 5km, which we take slowly and spread over 2-3 hours. It includes a gradual climb for most of the route, with one steep final section of around 30 minutes (total elevation gain around 650m). However, horses can be hired locally for around 3000Rs per person (approx. GBP 13 / USD 18) if you don't want to walk up. The trek in the mountains around Fairy Meadows on Day 4 you can make as hard or easy as you like. It's a beautiful place and just chilling out and enjoying the view for the day and not doing any walking would be fine.

On Day 5 we walk back down from Fairy Meadows again. This is nearly all downhill, and fairly easy walking apart from the first steep section. Horses can be hired again if required so you don't have to walk (you'd be led - you don't need to be an experienced rider at all).

Then on Day 6, the hike is around 8km / 4 hours at an easy pace, but this one is optional and you can skip it completely, or do a shorter version if you wish, according to how you feel. On Day 8 the walk to Khorpocho Fort is less than an hour there and back, but it's a steep narrow path and can be skipped if you wish. On Day 10, the walk at Borith Lake is around 2 hours up to the viewpoint, but can be shortened - you don't need to do the full thing.

Overall, you can do a lot of hiking if you wish, and it is a spectacular place to trek. However, you can also do much shorter walks, or miss them all out and just enjoy the scenery if you prefer. So, you don't need to be very physically fit to do this trip, but you do need to be comfortable with the options for the Fairy Meadows section.

6. Group Size/Tour Leaders/Guides

We are committed to being a small group operator, as we feel this gives everyone in the group the best chance to get to know their fellow travellers and to hear and make the most of their guide. There's no point in us providing great guides if you've got to peer over 30-40 shoulders to see them! So, we set our Pakistan small-group departures to have a maximum of 16 travellers. The minimum group size is 2.

In Pakistan we provide a fully trained, local English-speaking tour leader/driver to accompany our groups. Additional specialist local guides may be used for some of the sightseeing tours and activities included in the tour.

At Encounters Travel we have a policy of aiming to use only local Pakistani guides and reps wherever possible. We feel this provides support to the local population and economy and also gives you the best experience of the country and the sites you are seeing.

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Note: Please [download an up-to-date copy](#) of these tour notes shortly before you travel as itineraries and information does change from time to time.
